

Table 3.6: Percentage distribution of population by Broad Age Groups to Total population by Gender and Residence, India, 2011

Residence	Gender	Broad Age Groups (years)		
		0-14	15-59	60+
	Total	29.5	62.5	8.0
Total	Male	30.0	62.2	7.7
	Female	28.8	62.8	8.4
	Total	30.9	61.0	8.1
Rural	Male	31.5	60.7	7.8
	Female	30.3	61.3	8.4
	Total	25.5	66.6	7.9
Urban	Male	26.1	66.2	7.6
	Female	24.9	66.9	8.2

Note: Total percentage may not add to 100 on account of rounding in broad age groups

Source: Census of India (2011)

3.3.6 Life Expectancy

Life expectancy is the number of years a newborn child would live if subjected to the mortality risks prevailing for the population at the time of child's birth. In the period 1901-10, life expectancy was very low (23 years). The rise became substantial from 1951. It was 41.3 years in 1961, 45.6 years in 1971 and 50.5 years in 1981 and 63.4 years in 2004. At present it is 69 years with women expected to live for 70.4 years and men for 67.8 years.

3.3.7 Rural-Urban Migration

The process of economic development is associated with growth of urbanisation. The urban population has been growing rapidly since 1961. As per cent of total population, the urban population was about 11 per cent in 1901, about 18 per cent in 1961, about 26 per cent in 1991, 29 per cent in 2004 and 31 per cent in 2011. With slowing of the rate of growth of population and acceleration of industrialisation, the pace of rural-urban migration is expected to increase. Factors like higher incomes, job security, education, health, entertainment attract people to urban areas. The push and pull factors have played an important role in the degree of urbanisation.

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Elaborate the theory of Demographic Transition. Highlight the main trends of population in India.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

- 2) Explain the problem of missing women in India as coined by Prof. Amartya Sen.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

- 3) Explain the pattern of population growth in India since 1891.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

3.4 POPULATION GROWTH AND DEVELOPMENT

Economic development is possible when a nation optimally utilises labour force and capital so that productive potential is realised. Labour force expansion has positive and negative effects on the process of economic development. According to K. Sundaram the implications of growing demographic pressures in India for the process of development in general and the progress towards poverty eradication become clearer once we focus on the labour force consequences of the population growth. The magnitude of the addition to the workforce brings forth challenges pertaining to their productive absorption and capital constraints in the labour market. Skilling and training millions of youth entering the labour force is a herculean task for any government.

- 1) Population and Agriculture

The rising labour force puts pressure on land thereby reducing per-capita cultivated area. The fall in the cultivated land-man ratio can be compensated by making efforts to raise productivity. Irrigation potential if fully utilised can raise agricultural productivity and fulfil the requirements of rising population. With green revolution India has become self-sufficient in the production of food grains, but the distribution of food grains has still remained a critical issue. The incidence of nutritional deprivation and undernourishment has been highest in India. Hence the challenges of food production, food consumption and food availability have to be seen in this light.

- 2) Population Growth and Per-capita Income

A high growth rate of population has been a retarding factor to raise per-capita income. There is cumulative effect of the growth of population and increase in economic activity. This effect depends on several factors like

food and nutritional adequacy, environmental degradation, infrastructural pressures etc. Economic growth can also increase on sustainable basis if we improve the education and health status of the population and create productive employment opportunities for the people joining labour force. The advantages and the limitations of population growth depend on the pace of human capital formation and its deployment in productive activities.

3) Population and Unemployment

Rising population is accompanied by rise in the labour force that has a bearing on the problem of unemployment. Millions of youth enter labour force every year and absorption of all of them in the manufacturing and services sector is a challenging task. Generating employment opportunities to absorb the increasing labour force and the backlog of the unemployed pool has to be a priority of the government. Job creation requires significant amount of resources invested in infrastructure, tourism, manufacturing, construction, MSMEs, railways, etc. Similarly, promotion of women's employment opportunities and female literacy can play a vital role in harnessing the demographic dividend of the nation.

4) Population Growth and Environment

The demographic growth has implications on environmental resources, including on water resources, fodder and forest products, fisheries, air quality, soil, and other non-renewable resources. The degradation of environment has a deteriorating impact on the quality of life and well-being of the people. The greater reliance on solar and nuclear energy, judicious use of water resources, afforestation and organic farming can play a significant role in preserving the environment.

5) Population Growth and Social Infrastructure

Population growth leads to excessive pressure on social and economic infrastructure including sewage systems, hospital facilities, education institutions, highways, railways network, power grids, garbage-processing plants, and other public amenities. Due to urban agglomeration, there has been qualitative deterioration of social and physical or economic infrastructure. The pace of rural-urban migration has further increased slums in metropolitan cities burdening the already inadequate infrastructure resources. India needs to increase its expenditure on health and education to enhance labour productivity and employability. Creating quality education institutions at primary, secondary and tertiary level and expenditures on skill development and training are essential to take advantage of new and innovative technologies in future. Similarly, India suffers from problem of low doctor-population ratio and high out of pocket expenditure on health. Hence, by increasing public expenditure on health we can improve medical facilities and achieve goals of eradicating malnutrition and disease burden. The task of providing housing to every Indian requires allocation of resources and political will to execute the required social interventions.

3.4.1 Population Policy

The alarming increase in population calls for an effective population policy that can slow down the rate of population growth.